Simchat Torah — The Joy of Continuity

We've reached the finish line — coming into **Simchat Torah** through **Shemini Atzeret**, the culmination of everything that began in Tishrei.

The Deeper Simcha

Shemini Atzeret represents a deeper, more intimate kind of joy — a *separate simcha*.
By Sukkot, we said that *Sukkot* is called *Zman Simchateinu* — "the time of our joy" — yet it's still *Chag HaSukkot*.
But *this* Chag — *Shemini Atzeret* and *Simchat Torah* — is *Simchat HaTorah* itself: the joy *of* the Torah.

And the first miracle is simply this: every single year, *we still celebrate it*.
Despite thousands of years of attempts to prevent us, to erase us — here we are again, rejoicing.
That alone is reason enough for *simcha*: *I am here, I have persevered, I can smile, love, and laugh*.
But even more so, it's not just general happiness — it's *Simchat Torah*: joy *within* Torah itself.

Finishing and Beginning — The Eternal Cycle

On this Chag, we complete and begin anew:
we conclude *V'zot HaBerachah* and immediately begin *Sefer Bereishit*.
Within *Bereishit*, we encounter *Sheshet Yemei Beriat HaOlam* — the six days of creation — leading into the first Shabbat.

And then, the creation of *adam* — of mankind.
My grandfather, זכרונו לברכה, once pointed out something beautiful from his deep knowledge of *dikduk* and *lashon hakodesh*.

When Hashem says *"Na'aseh Adam b'tzalmenu"* — "Let us make man in our image" — Hashem is speaking, according to Chazal, to His heavenly court, the angels present at the moment of creation in Gan Eden. This exchange shows divine humility and partnership in creation.
The letter **bet** in *b'tzalmenu* can mean *in* our image, but it can also imply *with* our images — in the mind's eye, as a *tzelem* represents an image or reflection, like a mental picture.
My grandfather explained that *b'tzalmenu* not only reflects the plural expression of Hashem addressing His court but also holds deeper meaning. From Hashem's perspective, the truest expression is *b'tzalmi* — "in My image" — the pure unity of divine intention. Yet within humanity, *b'tzalmenu* represents the capacity to see and choose within the mind's imagination which "image" of Hashem to hold: the true one, rooted in divine awareness, or a distorted one that

leads toward *avodah zarah*.
Hashem gifted mankind with imagination and free will so that we might mirror His creativity and recognize His image consciously — but that same gift includes the danger of constructing false perceptions. In this way, *b'tzalmenu* becomes the foundation of human choice: the ability to perceive Hashem properly or to create a false mental image, a pattern that later unfolded in the generation of Enosh, who mistook the very forces Hashem empowered as independent divinities.

This understanding bridges directly to the next idea — that imagination itself is a divine gift carrying both holiness and risk: the power to imagine, to envision, and to create can build holiness or lead astray, depending on how it's used.

The Double-Edged Gift — Imagination and Avodah Zarah

When Hashem created *Adam Kadmon*, the first man, He gave humanity *seichel* and *dimyon*, intellect and imagination, beautiful tools meant for partnership with Hashem. Yet, these same abilities can also be misdirected toward falsehood, toward *avodah zarah*.

At *Har Sinai*, that imaginative faculty, the very *tzelem* Hashem implanted in us, was twisted into the creation of the *Egel HaZahav*, the golden calf.
They believed they needed an intermediary, an image.
That divine gift, meant to mirror Hashem's creative nature, became a source of illusion when detached from Him.

Moshe Rabbeinu — Creation Through Destruction

When Moshe Rabbeinu descended and saw *Bnei Yisrael* involved in the *cheit ha'eigel*,
he shattered the *Luchot*.

The Torah concludes *V'zot HaBerachah* with the words:

> *"וּלְכֹל֙ הַיָּ֣ד הַחֲזָקָ֔ה וּלְכֹ֖ל הַמּוֹרָ֑א אֲשֶׁ֨ר עָשָׂ֜ה מֹשֶׁ֗ה לְעֵינֵ֛י כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵ֖ל" — "And for all the mighty hand and all the great awe which Moshe performed before the eyes of all Israel."* (Devarim 34:12)

Rashi explains that this refers to Moshe's act of breaking the Luchot in full view of the nation — a deed of both strength and deep understanding. By doing so, Moshe protected Israel from greater harm, showing that sometimes the truest form of creation comes through destruction.

Moshe knew, through his divine insight and partnership with Hashem (the healthy and correct *tzelem* of *Adam Kadmon*), that destroying the Luchot at that moment would *create* something

greater:
a new covenant, a renewed connection.

Just as Hashem is both Creator and Destroyer,
Moshe too used his creative power to *break* — in order to *rebuild stronger*.

This is part of what it means to be *b'tzalmenu*:
to share not only Hashem's creative essence but also His very nature of creativity — the ability to use our divine likeness to build, renew, and transform.
It means channeling that creative power in a proper and holy way, discerning when to tear down in order to truly build.

Simcha in the Torah — The Joy of Renewal

That is the simcha of Torah — that through the Torah,
we can rebuild, realign, and reattach ourselves to the Divine will. Hashem wanted from the very beginning for us to not just be chess pieces in his game of creation but partners in it. B'tzelem Elokim, in his likeness with the ability to understand, absorb and create, our truest power and gift as human beings and as Jews.

Moshe Rabbeinu understood that the Torah was not given to angels,
but to human beings — *"lo bashamayim hi"* — it is here, in this world, close to us.
The Torah is meant for the human experience,
with all its pain, striving, and joy.

And so, even now — even in times of heartbreak, fear, and uncertainty —
Simchat Torah calls us to dance.

Because Torah existed before the world was created,
everything we experience is already known and guided by Hashem.
We can trust, with *emunah* and *bitachon*,
that Hashem loves us, wants the best for us,
and that everything we face is part of His greater design.

The Eternal Dance

Finishing the Torah is never the end. It marks a new beginning — flowing immediately into *Bereishit*, the story of creation and of humanity's divine gift of creativity and his ability to create and partner or to destroy through false ideas.
It's the joy of knowing that *we* are part of that eternal cycle —
the end becomes the beginning, and the beginning becomes the end.

Hashem created the world *for* Torah.
He created Adam so that Torah could be lived and passed forward.
We, *Klal Yisrael*, are woven into that eternal rhythm — the Torah's heartbeat.

And so, we dance.
We dance with the Torah, because through it, we know that our people,
our children, and our purpose continue forever.

Closing Blessing

May this year bring **simcha** like never before.
May our losses and pain be transformed into new light and higher joy.
May we dance harder than ever —
knowing that *Torah Tzivah Lanu Moshe, Morashah Kehilat Yaakov* —
the Torah Moshe commanded us is our inheritance forever —
both the gift we receive and the one we pass on.

Chag Sameach.